

PART TWO

How to Succeed in Business by Really Trying WHAT MAKES AN EXECUTIVE?

As part of a university survey designed to gauge their understanding of business theories and practices, several hundred entering freshmen recently were asked this question:

"Assuming that you owned a large business firm, what is the principal quality, trait or qualification you would want your executives to possess?"

Among the answers were these random—but fairly typical—examples:

"I'd want my executives to dress well and have good personalities."

"They would have to know how to entertain important customers."

"I'd only hire executives who could keep prices up and wages down."

"I'd insist on getting executives who were able to make people work harder and faster."

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Now, naive as these replies may sound, one cannot blame freshmen for being somewhat hazy about what goes on in the business world. Unfortunately, their ignorance is shared by far too many who are much older and should be much wiser. The principles of management personnel selection are often misunderstood, even by some who have long been active in the management of businesses. I have encountered more than a few supposedly experienced businessmen whose concepts of the qualities and qualifications they or other management personnel should possess are nearly as muddled as those of the students.